

became a serious one. I've always loved archery, shooting, watching, and just being around people when they were shooting. That was my home," he says.

Archery, he adds, simply made sense. "What I like most about archery is that there's no real chance for cheating. Outside of the smallest local events, it's very clear what you've shot. I felt it's the fairest sport in the world, and because of that, most archers are very easy to get along with," he says.

While it was perhaps inevitable that Mete would become an archer, he tried several other sports. "I played all sorts of sports. I was actually a pretty good pistol shooter. I still shoot for fun. After the Tokyo Olympics, I shot a round of 572 in practice, which isn't far off Olympic qualification. Maybe if I'd chosen to be an air-pistol shooter, it might have been me rather than Dikec at the Olympics! But I always knew I was going to be an archer," he says.

Early rise

Mete, who began competing in archery at seven, was taking part in senior events by 12, made his first national team at 14, won individual silver at the European Championships at 16, and competed in his first Olympics, at Rio de Janeiro, a few months later, where he lost in the round of 32 to eventual fourth-place finisher Sjef van den Berg of the Netherlands.

All the while, he was refining his technique. At 1.82 m tall, Mete's long arms limit the draw weight he can handle. The higher the draw weight, the faster (and theoretically more accurate) the arrow. He currently uses a 53-pound bow, lighter than the 55 used by India's Dhiraj Bommadevara and far less than the 58 of London

Olympic champion Mauro Nespoli. Though his lighter draw means he can take slightly longer to line up, he's actually one of the fastest shooters at the world level.

His breakthrough came at the 2018 World Cup Final in Berlin, where he beat future Korean Olympic champion Lee Woo Seok, a performance that earned him his first of three World Archery Player of the Year awards.

That result made him a top contender for Tokyo 2020, a responsibility Mete handled superbly. Since then, he has remained consistent at major events, winning individual golds at the 2023 World Championships and 2024 European Championships, followed by a team bronze in Paris, each celebrated with his trademark pose.

Gaming marathoner

A life devoted to archery has meant some compromises. "I realised early that I couldn't go to school like other children because I'd usually be training or competing. So I mostly studied at home and went to school only for exams. I was a smart kid, and I sometimes wish I'd studied engineering or something, but even that was because I wanted to understand the technology behind the bow," he says.

Though archery is his first passion, Mete has others too. His love for anime began when, as a bored 14-year-old at a national

camp, he needed something to watch. "I'm a fan of a lot of different shows. I'm currently a fan of *One Piece*, but before that, I was into *Demon Slayer*, *Baki*, *Seven Deadly Sins*, and *Fairy Tail*. I think I've watched 20 episodes in one go at times," he says.

But his second-greatest passion might be video games. "Sometimes when archery gets too much, I relax by playing video games, but then I end up getting obsessed. There have been times when, if I don't have practice that day, I'll play for 14 or 15 hours and get maybe three hours of sleep. My record was staying up 60 hours straight playing League of Legends. My excuse was that it was during the COVID pandemic when we weren't sure the Tokyo Olympics would happen. People later joked that my secret for winning gold was staying up three days gaming. The truth is, once I realised the Olympics were back on, I focused again on archery," he says.

For now, Mete remains focused on his sport. For all the medals he has won, he isn't done yet. "There are still a lot of medals I want. I want to win an Olympic team gold and the mixed-team gold.

I haven't won those yet. I don't think I'm very far from it. It's all a matter of one arrow," he says. And when that moment comes, he'll bring out his trademark celebration again. "That won't change. I'll always do that," he says.

Rising force: Turkiye's archery trio (L-R) Abdullah Yildirmis, Berkim Tumer and Mete Gazoz celebrate their team bronze at Paris 2024, their smiles reflecting a nation's quiet ascent in the sport. GETTYIMAGES

